

A startup for the next billion

AUGUST HAS BEEN OUR INDEPENDENCE

SPECIAL ISSUE for quite a few years. Being a tech magazine, it's when we celebrate technology milestones that India has achieved in the last year. We've had plenty to write about the likes of apps and startups that have made their mark. Most often, these are heavily inspired replications of apps from existing global markets. I'm not saying that we don't have anything original to show. Our space programme has bedazzled even the brightest minds as to how we can achieve similar objectives at a fraction of the cost. Videos and articles showcasing Desi jugaad often become viral across the globe. So we have innovations serving the undeserved and innovations serving the highest order but there seems to be an abject lack of innovation right down the middle of the spectrum - the one that serves the mainstream market.

During one of my recent travels I had the privilege of sitting right next to a research scholar from IIT-Bombay. He was returning home after having presented a paper at a prestigious conference. Not wanting to miss the opportunity to dig into the research domain, I began to network with the individual. My aim, to identify a few researchers and colleges that I could reach out to for a few stories. Getting to cover cutting edge research isn't a simple task so I set about prodding to find out which domains have the most exciting work going on for them. I wasn't prepared for what came next. Apparently, there isn't much original research emerging from Indian universities. The lack of infrastructure, motivation, incentive, mentors, lax standards of peer review, etc. seem to have brought about a culture that's reminiscent of a government office.

The ones who are truly passionate tend to hunt for universities where they can perform research under the guidance of a mentor who cares. Personally, all of my friends who went on to get into academic research have since long moved out of the country in pursuit of better opportunities. These aren't even folks with deep pockets who're

heading out because it's an easy option for them. Even in the non-research oriented fields, we see the same feedback. Plenty of multinational firms have commented on the "skill-gap" that is characteristic of Indian engineering graduates. Having witnessed this in person, I'm afraid to say that I do concur.

The whole thing about revamping the education system has been said a million times and it's going to be decades before we sort that out. What is needed is a multi-pronged approach to help our students understand concepts better. We already have Massive Online Open Courses that aim to remedy this situation, however, the vast majority are in English and that's no good for the vast majority of our students. Even the Indian educational startups are syllabus driven because that's where the money is. A Math & Science video course on one of these websites can cost upwards of Rs. 25K. You can be pretty certain that this is well beyond the reach of most students.

Aside from Khan Academy, there are barely any services to serve this vastly underserved market. There is no money in it but it certainly would help the country grow by leaps and bounds. All we need is for some Indian or overseas organisation to take charge and solve this truly Indian problem. **d**



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